

HKEY_CURRENT_USER: This branch stores data related to the currently logged-in user. Any customisation you do to Windows or your applications is stored under this branch. This branch has a lot of customisation options, and they can be edited to suit your needs.

HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE: This branch has information related to the computer and the applications installed on it. This also happens to be the most edited branch. An important thing to remember is that the changes made here are reflected globally—that is, they are independent of the user. The ‘SOFTWARE’ key under this branch offers customisation options for all installed applications, and for Windows too.

HKEY_USER: Pretty much like the ‘HKEY_CURRENT_USER’ branch, ‘HKEY_USER’ contains configuration data specific to the individual user. Users are identified by a Security Identifier (SID), a unique value assigned to a user on creation. As against ‘CURRENT_USER’, ‘HKEY_USER’ has information related to all the user accounts created on the machine.

HKEY_CURRENT_CONFIG: This key is connected to HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE in much the same way as HKEY_USER is to HKEY_CURRENT_USER. This branch contains data specific to the hardware and software settings for all users of the machine.

As mentioned earlier, each of these branches are “keys”, denoted by a folder icon. The keys further have sub-keys and values that make up the Registry data. Apart from these five keys, there are other notations that you should be familiar with.

REG_DWORD: A REG_DWORD acts like a switch: it can have one of two values—“0” or “1”. DWORD is the most commonly tweaked or edited value while editing the Registry. You can create a new DWORD in the Registry Editor by going to Edit > New, and selecting ‘DWORD Value’. The value is usually denoted in the hexadecimal format with the decimal equivalent in brackets next to it.